

Stiefel and Grassmann Manifolds: A Geometric Foundation for Orthogonality and Subspace Problems in Machine Learning

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Abstract

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1 Introduction

2 Preliminaries

We follow the conventions of [2] and [1].

2.1 Basic Definitions

Definition 2.1 (Co-ordinate Chart). Let X be a topological space. A **Co-ordinate Chart** on X is the pair (U, φ) where $U \subset X$ is an open set, such that there exists a homeomorphism

$$\varphi : U \xrightarrow{\sim} \varphi(U) \subset \mathbb{R}^n$$

for some natural number $n \in \mathbb{N}$.

Definition 2.2 (Topological Manifold). Let X be a topological space, and fix a natural number $n \in \mathbb{N}$. X is an **n-dimensional topological manifold** if and only if for any point $x \in X$, there exists a co-ordinate chart where,

$$\varphi : U \xrightarrow{\sim} \varphi(U) \subset \mathbb{R}^n$$

where $x \in U$

This is to say, that X is locally Euclidean, i.e. X is homeomorphic to $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Furthermore, we require that X is Hausdorff, and second countable, as to exclude certain pathological examples.

Definition 2.3 (Transition Function). Let X be a topological manifold, and let (U, φ_1) and (V, φ_2) be two co-ordinate charts on X . The **transition function** between these two co-ordinate charts is the function:

$$\phi_{21} = \varphi_2 \circ \varphi_1^{-1} : \varphi_1(U \cap V) \xrightarrow{\sim} \varphi_2(U \cap V)$$

Notice, it is automatically a homeomorphism, as it is the composition of two homeomorphisms.

Its inverse is the transition function in the opposite direction:

$$\phi_{21}^{-1} = \phi_{12} = \varphi_1 \circ \varphi_2^{-1} : \varphi_2(U \cap V) \xrightarrow{\sim} \varphi_1(U \cap V)$$

Definition 2.4 (Smooth Atlas). Let X be a topological manifold. An **atlas** on X is a collection of co-ordinate charts on X :

$$\varphi_i : U_i \xrightarrow{\sim} \tilde{U}_i \subset \mathbb{R}^n$$

indexed by some, possibly infinite, set I , such that:

$$\bigcup_{i \in I} U_i = X$$

An atlas is a **smooth atlas** if and only if for any two co-ordinate charts in the atlas, the transition function

$$\phi_{ij} = \varphi_j \circ \varphi_i^{-1} : \varphi_i(U_i \cap U_j) \xrightarrow{\sim} \varphi_j(U_i \cap U_j), \quad i, j \in I$$

is a smooth function, i.e. it is infinitely differentiable.

Definition 2.5 (Compatible smooth atlases). Let X be a topological manifold, and let

$$\mathcal{A} = \{(U_i, \varphi_i); i \in I\}$$

be a smooth atlas on X . Let (U, φ) be any coordinate chart on X . The chart (U, φ) is **compatible** with the atlas $\mathcal{A}$ if and only if the transition functions between (U, φ) and any chart in $\mathcal{A}$ are diffeomorphisms, i.e. they are smooth functions with smooth inverses.

In other words, the new chart (U, φ) is compatible with the atlas $\mathcal{A}$ if and only if the union $\mathcal{A} \cup \{(U, \varphi)\}$ is still a smooth atlas. Let $\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{B}$ be smooth atlases on X . The atlases $\mathcal{A}$ and $\mathcal{B}$ are **compatible** if and only if every chart in $\mathcal{A}$ is compatible with $\mathcal{B}$, and vice versa.

Corollary 2.6. *Compatibility is an equivalence relation on smooth atlases. [Segal, Corollary 2.20].*

Definition 2.7 (Smooth structure and smooth manifold).

2.2 Examples

Example 2.8.

Example 2.9.

3 Motivation

4 The Stiefel Manifold

Definition 4.1.

Remark 4.2.

5 The Grassmann Manifold

Lemma 5.1.

Proof.

□

Proposition 5.2.

Proof.

□

6 From Stiefel to Grassmann

Theorem 6.1.

Proof.

□

Corollary 6.2.

Proof.

□

7 Worked Example: $\text{Gr}(2, 4)$

7.1 First Application

7.2 Second Application

8 Discussion

9 Further Directions

10 Conclusion

References

- [1] Nicolas Boumal, *An introduction to optimization on smooth manifolds*, Cambridge University Press, 2023.
- [2] Ed Segal, *Manifolds*, 2016, Lecture notes, University College London.